

SELFIE TIME CM Jairam Thakur with Union MoS for culture Meenakshi Lekhi at a public meeting in Mandi, Sept. 29

ANI

list goes on. The post-Covid pains of the tourism industry—it contributes 7 per cent to the state GDP—hasn't subsided either. What the CM has going for him are his government's relatively clean image, the plethora of social sector schemes and his government's efforts to expand and improve infrastructure, health facilities and education. This includes creating a network of heliports connecting several towns in the state, including the ones in Shimla, Baddi (Solan district) and Rampur which were completed under the UDAN (Ude Desh ka Aam Nagrik) scheme. Work on the heliports at Kangnidhar (Mandi) and Manali are on. The heli-taxi services on the Shimla-Rampur route started in December 2021 with three flights a week. CM Thakur believes the network will increase tourist penetration in the inner pockets of the state.

However, will all this get him the votes? The BJP's internal assessment is that "at least 30 fresh faces" need to contest. Sources say the list of those who face the axe includes four ministers, five over-70 MLAs, a few faces who may lose the anti-incumbency test, and those who lost in the previous assembly election. This has made the Dhumal faction more anxious. In June this year, CM Thakur had got two independent MLAs, Hoshiyar Singh and Pawan Rana, into the BJP. In the previous assembly polls, they had defeated BJP candidates Ravinder Ravi (a close associate of Dhumal) and Gulab Singh Thakur (Anurag's father-in-law), respectively. There is a strong lobby in the state BJP which believes Anurag's appeal among the youth is underutilised. The Union minister is heir to his father's legacy; it adds up to influence in 14 assembly seats in his Lok Sabha segment Hamirpur and another 20 in lower HP.

Jairam Thakur has also been developing his home base, the Sehraj region of Mandi, and now has influence in 30-odd seats. He has engineered the defections of Congress MLAs from Kangra (Pawan Kajal) and Nalagarh (Lakhwinder Rana), the return of suspended IT cell convenor and rebel Chetan Bragta and dissuaded ex-minister and rebel Anil Sharma (son of ex-Union minister Sukh Ram) from leaving. In the last week of September, the BJP also got Congress state president Harsh Mahajan to cross over. Mahajan, an ex-Virbhadra loyalist, has connections in Chamba/ Kangra districts.

The party is also eyeing the vote of communities like the Haati in the trans-Giri region in Sirmaur district who were recently added to the Scheduled Tribes (ST) list. They are traditional Congress voters, but could be more amiable this time after the award that CM Thakur has taken credit for. Sirmaur district, bordering Uttarakhand, sends five MLAs to the assembly. In 2017, the BJP had won three seats and the Congress two but all five were tight contests. Come November, BJP leaders will be hoping Thakur's political marksmanship is a lot better than on the shooting range. ■

UP/ RELIGIOUS AFFAIRS DEPT

A HOLY PUSH

By Prashant Srivastava

If there is one entity that has benefited from the Yogi Adityanath government's push for religious tourism, it is the hitherto innocuous Dharmarth Karya Vibhaag (religious affairs department) of the Uttar Pradesh administration. Set up in 1985, it was seen as a punishment assignment for bureaucrats and always got a minimal budgetary allocation. But there's a turn in its fortunes now. The department has proposed a whopping Rs 1,000 crore budget for FY23 compared to the Rs 32.52 crore it spent in 2017-18. It has also been given several pilgrimage development projects, among them an online integrated temple information system, containing the

FROM Rs 32.52 CRORE IT SPENT IN FY18, THE DEPARTMENT HAS PROPOSED Rs 1,000 CRORE FOR FY23

descriptions, details and history of all temples in the state as well as the route maps, for the convenience of pilgrims. The department will also oversee the construction of the Janmabhoomi Path, Bhakti Path and Ram Path, three pathways to connect various sites in Ayodhya to the main Ram temple. Work is going on by way of demolition of old buildings to make way for the corridor. In addition, the department has been asked to constitute a "special board" that can effectively implement schemes for the overall welfare of elderly saints, pujaris and purohits.

The department also plans to operate the Kailash Mansarovar Bhawan in Ghaziabad and work on the construction of the second phase